

Knights' FIFA 2026 Draft

The bottom line

Six players draft World Cup teams and score points as their teams advance; most points wins. Two settings decide whether it's fair and fun:

1. **Teams per player** → **8**. That uses all 48 teams, so everyone has a full squad and the champion is always owned. 4, 5, or 6 work equally well — the number barely affects who wins.
2. **Points per round** → "**Building**": **1, 3, 6, 10, 15, 21** (for reaching the Round of 32, Round of 16, Quarter-final, Semi-final, Final, and winning).

This keeps draft seats reasonably fair, makes ties rare, and rewards good drafting — without reducing the pool to "who got the champion." The same settings hold for 7 or 8 players, with a growing first-pick advantage the only real change (§3f). Basis: the tournament simulated 50,000 times under each rule set.

1. How we tested it

- Give each of the 48 teams a strength rating (real published ratings; bigger gap = bigger favourite).
- Play the full 104-match tournament on the computer — stronger teams win more often, upsets still happen. The group stage, "8 best third-placed teams" rule, and knockout bracket follow FIFA's 2026 format.
- Replay it 50,000 times per rule set to see what usually happens.
- Draft teams for the 6 players and total everyone's points in every tournament.

Scoring example (Building ladder): a team knocked out in the quarter-final earns 6 points; a team that wins the World Cup earns 21. Your score is the sum across your teams.

2. The three scoring systems

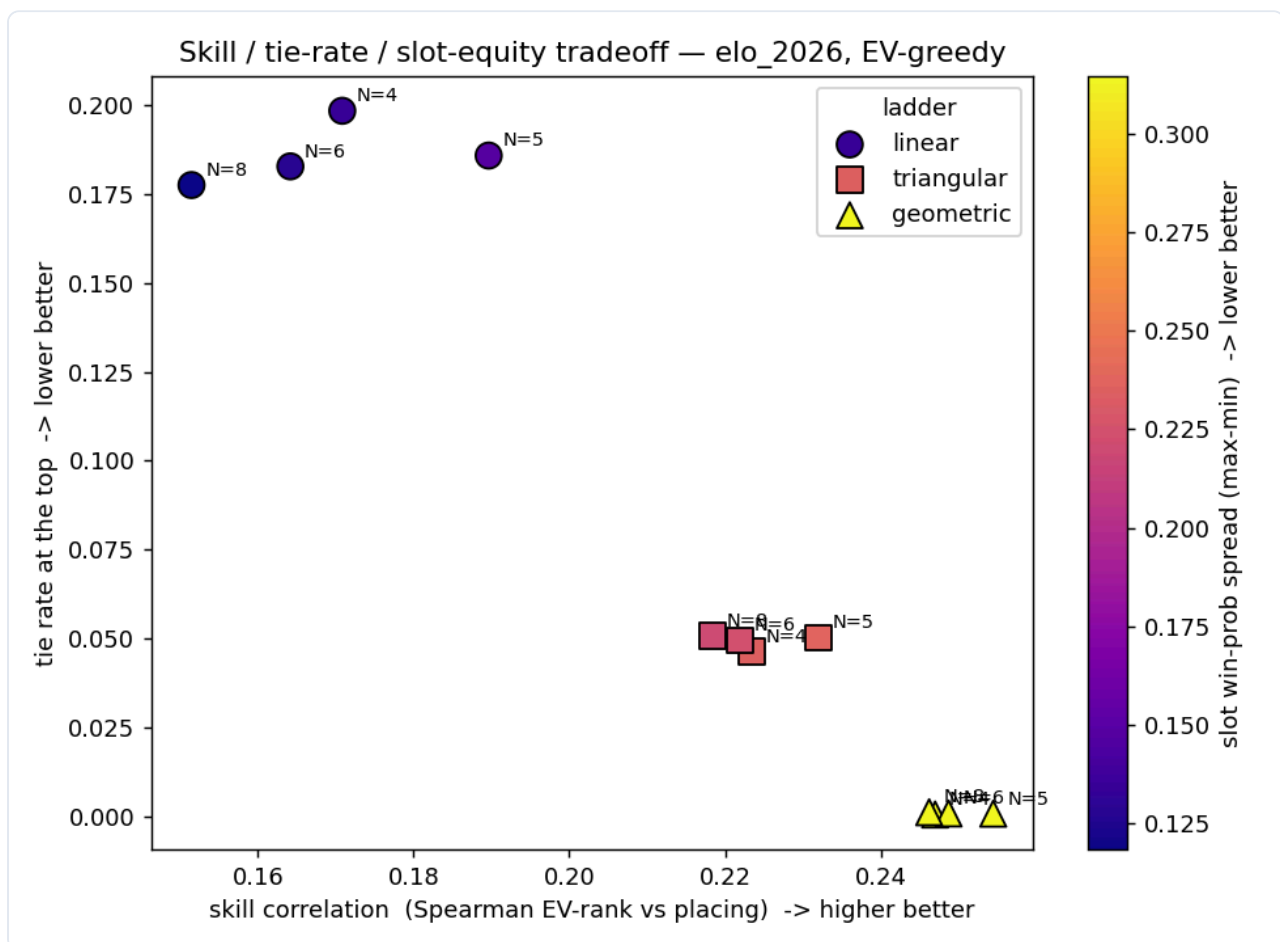
Each gives 0 points for a team that doesn't escape the group stage.

Reach →	R32	R16	QF	SF	Final	Champion
Steady (linear)	1	2	3	4	5	6
Building (triangular)	1	3	6	10	15	21
Doubling (geometric)	1	2	4	8	16	32

They differ in how much the late rounds matter: Steady makes a champion worth 6× a first-round team; Doubling makes it 32×.

3. Results

3a. The core trade-off



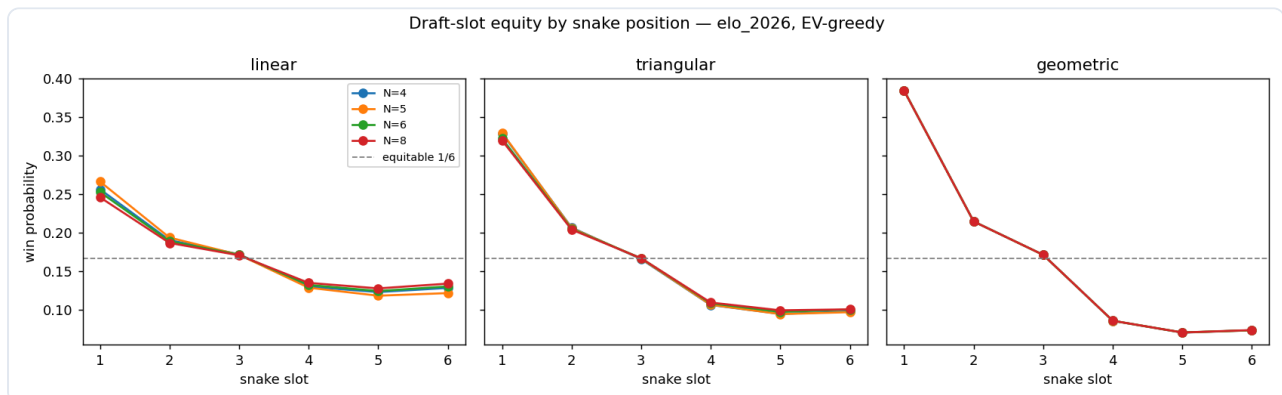
Each marker is one rule set: right = more skill, down = fewer ties, colour = seat fairness (dark = fair, yellow = unfair). The markers best for skill and ties (bottom-right) are the worst for fairness. You can't win all three at once.

3b. The numbers (real 2026 field)

	Steady	Building	Doubling
Better drafter finishes higher? (0 = chance, 1 = always)	0.17	0.22	0.25
Share of the result the draft explains (rest is luck)	~4%	~7%	~9%
Tie at the top	19%	5%	0.1%
1st-seat win chance (fair = 16.7%)	26%	33%	38%
Last-seats win chance (5th/6th)	12–13%	10%	7%
Champion's owner wins the pool	51%	77%	99.9%

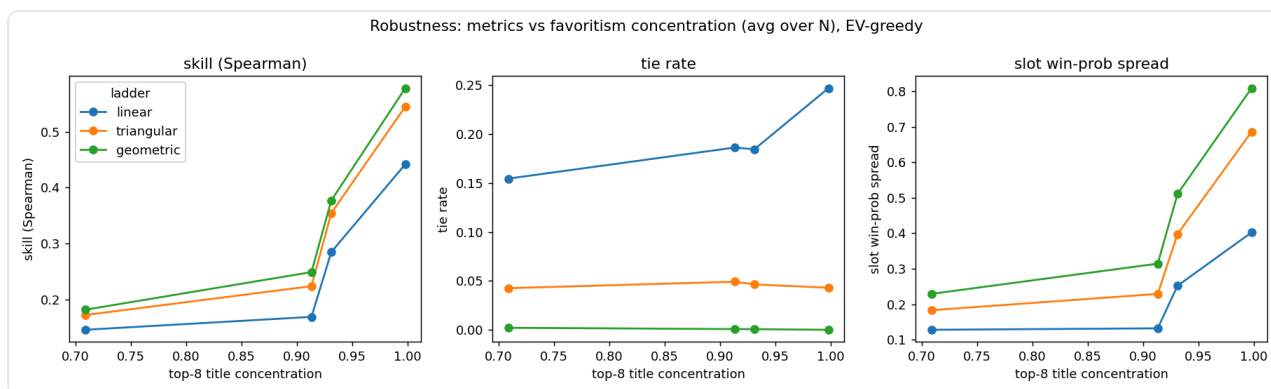
The draft is a weak lever — even under Doubling it explains under 10% of who wins; the rest is luck. The steeper the scoring, the more the first seat dominates and the more the pool becomes "who owns the champion."

3c. Seat fairness



Win chance by draft seat (1 picks first ... 6 last); dashed line = fair 16.7%. Doubling is most lopsided (first seat ~38%, late seats ~7%); Building is gentler; Steady is flattest but tie-prone.

3d. Does it hold if favourites are stronger or weaker?



Re-run from an even field to a top-heavy one (left to right). The order never changes: Doubling gives the most skill and fewest ties, Steady the fairest seats. Seat unfairness grows with a top-heavy field — and the 2026 field is top-heavy.

3e. You can't game the draft

A "shark" drafting cleverly did no better than just taking the best available team, under every system. Simple drafting is fine.

3f. What if 7 or 8 people play?

The conclusions don't change — same ladder ordering, same recommendation. Holding 6 teams each and only adding players (real 2026 field, Building ladder unless noted):

	6 players	7 players	8 players
Skill	0.22	0.25	0.27
First pick's edge over a fair share	1.9×	2.3×	2.6×
Tie rate	5%	5%	5%

- **The first-pick advantage grows** — the main thing that changes. Each player's fair share shrinks (1-in-6 → 1-in-8) while grabbing the single best team is just as valuable, so going first matters more: ~1.9× a fair share at 6 players rises to ~2.6× at 8 (and to ~3× under the steep "Doubling" ladder).
- **Skill rises slightly.** With more players each drafting 6 teams, more of the 48-team field is owned, so the luck-driven swings in each score shrink (the tournament-noise part drops ~20% from 6 to 8 players) and the better drafter is rewarded a bit more. It's a small but genuine effect — not a quirk of comparing more players — and the pool stays mostly luck.

- **Ties and the ladder order hold** for Building and Doubling; only the flat "Steady" ladder gets more tie-prone with more players (18% → 22%).

So 7 or 8 works fine. The growing first-pick advantage is the main reason to keep the group smaller, set a clear pick order, or use an auction (\$5) as you scale up.

4. What it means

One dial controls everything: how steep the scoring is.

- Steeper (Doubling): more skill, almost no ties — but a big first-pick advantage and a pool that's really about the champion.
- Flatter (Steady): fairer seats — but frequent ties and more luck.

Either way the pool is mostly luck: the best scoring still leaves over 90% of the result to chance. The number of teams per player doesn't change this.

5. How other pools score

- **March Madness brackets:** ~81% use a fixed points-per-round system; the most common is 1-2-4-8-16-32 (~70%) — our "Doubling" (TeamRankings). Many use gentler ladders to stop the champion dominating — Fibonacci 2-3-5-8-13-21, or 1-3-6-10-15-20 (PrintYourBrackets), nearly identical to our "Building." Some add upset bonuses.
- **World Cup sweepstakes:** teams drawn from a hat — pure luck (FourFourTwo).
- **Pick'em / progressive pick'em:** predict match results; later rounds pay more, in linear (1,2,3...) or doubling (1,2,4...) variants (PoolTracker).
- **Auction / Calcutta:** bid money for teams; anyone can win any team, so the draft-seat advantage disappears — at the cost of more complexity.

6. Recommendations

Teams per player: 8. Uses all 48 teams; everyone has a full squad; the champion is always owned. 4–6 are equally competitive — pick for convenience.

Scoring: Building (1, 3, 6, 10, 15, 21). Near the skill of steeper scoring, ties rare (~5%), without the first-pick blowout or "all about the champion."

Want	Use	Cost
Balanced (recommended)	Building 1-3-6-10-15-21	mild first-seat edge; ~5% ties
Pure skill, no ties	Doubling 1-2-4-8-16-32	first seat wins ~38%; pool $\approx$ champion
Fairest seats	Steady 1-2-3-4-5-6	~19% ties; needs a tiebreaker

Set a tiebreaker in advance (e.g., most teams reaching the Final). If equal seats matter most, use an auction instead of a snake draft.